Official Pickleball Rules and Governance (1984)

I. Governance and Mission

In 1984, USA Pickleball (USAPA) was officially established to transition the game from a backyard pastime to a competitive sport. This first official rulebook was created to standardize the chaotic variations found in different regions.

II. Equipment & Court Standards

Court dimensions are officially locked at 20' x 44'. Wood remains the primary material for paddles, though composite experiments are beginning. The 'kitchen' is now strictly defined as the 7-foot Non-Volley Zone.

III. Service Mechanics and Evolution

The 'Volley Serve' is the only legal serve. It must be underhand with an upward arc. This era sees the first ban on 'throwing' the ball during a serve to prevent extreme spin manipulation early in the game's history.

IV. Gameplay Dynamics

The Two-Bounce Rule is formalized here to prevent the 'serve-and-slam' style from ruining the family-friendly pacing of the game. Scoring is set to 11 points, win by 2.

V. Conduct and Professionalism

Early conduct rules focus on local 'neighborly' sportsmanship. Players are expected to call their own lines and resolve disputes without a referee.